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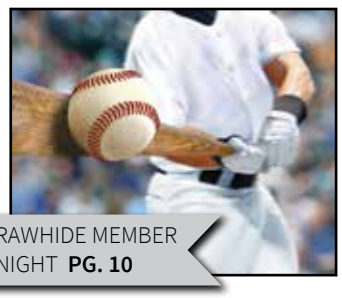

RAWHIDE MEMBER NIGHT **PG. 10**

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Where Things Stand: MidKings GSA Stakeholder Committee Update – Spring 2025

by Julie Martella

If you've been watching SGMA developments from a distance, now's a good time to check back in. The decisions taking shape this spring will influence how we manage groundwater, support our communities, and protect our agricultural future here in Kings County.

The Mid-Kings River GSA Board of Directors established a Stakeholder Advisory Committee to bring local expertise and knowledge into the heart of SGMA policy discussions following the resignation of the Kings County Water District. The committee includes various landowners, a water district representative, county staff, and technical experts.

When the committee approves a recommendation, it is sent to legal counsel and the GSA Board of Directors for consideration. The goal is to ensure that SGMA policy is informed, practical, and shaped by those who live and work in the region.

Here's a look at where things stand this spring.

Well Registration: A Clearer Picture of What Exists

One of the biggest wins this season has been the stakeholder committee's approval of a well registration policy, which has now been recommended to the Board of Directors for final action.

Under the policy, all new wells installed after the policy's effective date, including domestic wells, must be registered within 90 days of either being drilled or changing ownership. Landowners must notify the county if a permit is issued, but the well is delayed.

The goal is not to create more red tape but to make certain that the Mid-Kings GSA has accurate, real-time data on wells. This won't require much effort for most landowners. However, it's an essential step toward building a better local understanding of how many wells are in use.

Abandoned Wells: Capturing Data and Creating Opportunity

Abandoned wells pose a threat to the area. State water regulators currently show many more active wells than actually exist. Without accurate local documentation, these outdated records may result in overcounts, increasing the risk of overregulation, reducing local decision-making authority, and setting the stage for potentially misguided water policy.

To address this, the advisory committee approved a proposal to build a local database of abandoned wells, and that recommendation is now in the hands of the Board of Directors. This database would serve two purposes:

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Enhancing Rural Security: The Critical Role of Flock Cameras in Combating Agricultural Crime

Agriculture is the backbone of Kings County, supporting countless families and businesses. However, as with any industry, it faces challenges, and one of the most persistent issues is agricultural crime. From stolen equipment to copper wire theft, criminals target farms and rural properties, causing financial loss and disrupting essential operations.

Fortunately, the Kings County Ag Crimes Unit, a partnership between the Kings County Sheriff and District Attorney, is taking proactive steps to combat these crimes. One of the most effective tools in their arsenal is the Flock Camera system, an innovative technology that is revolutionizing how rural crimes are investigated and solved.

What Are Flock Cameras?

Flock Cameras are a specialized surveillance system designed to capture images of passing vehicles, explicitly focusing on license plates. Unlike traditional security cameras, these cameras are built with advanced image recognition technology, allowing law enforcement to track and identify suspect vehicles more efficiently.

When a crime occurs, investigators can use Flock Camera data to trace the movement of suspects, determine their point of entry, and identify potential getaway routes.

The Expansion of Flock Camera Usage

Initially introduced in Kings County through a grant program, Flock Cameras have since expanded into various communities, including Hanford, Lemoore, Corcoran, and Avenal. The Kings County Sheriff's Office has installed a number of these cameras in fixed locations throughout the county, creating a growing network of surveillance that enhances rural security.

However, criminals are constantly adapting, often changing locations to avoid detection. Recognizing this challenge, the Ag Crimes Unit has sought to incorporate mobile Flock Cameras into its strategy. Unlike permanently mounted cameras, mobile units are battery—or solar-powered and can be placed strategically in crime hotspots. These portable

"Security" continued on page 5

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Values
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Reliable | Trusted Resource

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Executive Director
Dusty Ference
dusty.ference@kcfb.org

Farm Life Advertising
Breanna Larman
blarman@kcfb.org
(559) 584-3557

Farm Life Designer
Beth Greene

CFBF District Representative
Kevin Robertson

Contact
870 Greenfield Ave., Hanford, CA 93230
Phone: (559) 584-3557
www.kcfb.org

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My Commitment to Local Control in Groundwater Management

By Dusty Ference, Executive Director

Dusty Ference

I recently had the opportunity to share my views on sustainable groundwater management at both the Urban Water Institute (UWI) Spring Conference and the Water Association of Kern County event. I want to share my perspective with you directly.

At UWI, I presented "Silos in SGMA," where I discussed the shortcomings of the State Water Resources Control Board (SWRCB) and their decision to place the Tulare Lake Subbasin on probation under SGMA. I explained that while state mandates are designed to protect our water resources, they often miss critical issues like protecting rural communities and the local economies driven by agriculture. I warned that if state mandates continue without incorporating the practical insights of local water managers, the agricultural backbone of our communities will be at serious risk.

From left to right, Jennifer Persike, moderator; Dusty Ference, KCFB; Allison Febbo, General Manager Westlands Water District; and Lacey McBride, Water Resources Manager, Merced County.

During the Kern County event, I emphasized the need for collaboration between state agencies and local stakeholders. I shared real-world examples from Kings County to illustrate how family farmers, with their deep knowledge of local water systems, can craft realistic and sustainable water management strategies. I firmly believe that a one-size-fits-all approach can lead to inflexible policies that harm our agricultural communities rather than help them.

My goal is to champion local control in water management by advocating for policies that blend sound science with on-the-ground expertise. As we face the challenges presented by SGMA, I remain dedicated to ensuring that our regulatory measures empower our communities and protect the livelihoods of those who feed our state.

Thank you for your continued support as we work together to secure a sustainable water future for California.

Kings County Farm Bureau Congratulates Aubrey Bettencourt on Appointment as NRCS Chief

Hanford, CA – The Kings County Farm Bureau is thrilled to congratulate Aubrey Bettencourt on her appointment as Chief of the Natural Resources Conservation Service (NRCS) at the United States Department of Agriculture (USDA). As a third-generation farmer and a former member of the Kings County Farm Bureau's Board of Directors, Aubrey's new role is a reflection of her deep commitment to agriculture and conservation, values that have always resonated strongly with our community.

Aubrey's extensive experience in both the agricultural and conservation sectors has made her an invaluable advocate for California's farmers and ranchers. Having served as President and CEO of the Almond Alliance of California, Deputy Assistant Secretary for Water and Science at the U.S. Department of the Interior, and California State Executive Director of USDA's Farm Service Agency, Aubrey has a proven track record of leadership. Her time spent on our Board of Directors allowed her to connect deeply with the local agricultural community, and she remains a trusted ally of Kings County farmers.

"Aubrey's appointment is a proud moment for us, as we've seen firsthand the dedication she brings to the table," said Kings County Farm Bureau. "Her leadership and understanding of both farming and conservation make her uniquely suited to lead NRCS during this crucial time. We are excited to continue working with her to ensure that California's farmers and ranchers remain successful and that our natural resources are protected for future generations."

Under Aubrey's leadership, the NRCS will continue to play a pivotal role in helping farmers, ranchers, and forest landowners across the country achieve their conservation goals. We are confident that her experience and passion will guide NRCS in its important mission to promote sustainable agriculture and environmental stewardship.

The Kings County Farm Bureau looks forward to working alongside Chief Bettencourt and NRCS as we tackle the challenges of today's agricultural landscape.

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Senator Grove Champions an Ag Overtime Tax Credit

A coalition of farm and ranch advocacy groups joined Senator Shannon Grove (R–Bakersfield) on California Ag Day for a press conference held on the grounds of the State Capitol. Senator Grove, author of the Farm Bureau-sponsored SB 628, is championing legislation that would allow farm and ranch employers to be reimbursed for the cost of overtime wages—specifically, the "half" in "time-and-a-half"—through a payroll tax deduction.

Speaking at the event, Senator Grove emphasized her support for the bill, "California's farmers and farmworkers are the backbone of our agricultural economy. Unfortunately, overtime mandates have made it harder for farmworkers to get the hours they need and for growers to get their product to market." SB 628 is scheduled to be heard in the Senate Labor, Public Employment and Pensions Committee on April 23.

EPA to Revise Wotus Rule

The EPA recently announced that it is looking to promulgate a new rule concerning the Clean Water Act (often referred to as the Waters of the U.S., or WOTUS). According to an EPA press release, the agency aims to update guidance that "follows the law, reduces red tape, cuts overall permitting costs, and lowers the cost of doing business in communities across the country while protecting the nation's navigable waters from pollution. "WOTUS has posed a regulatory hurdle for many in the agriculture sector for years due to inconsistent and often impractical enforcement of the Act. While a major Supreme Court case in 2023 helped pave the way for some relief, the previous administration followed it with guidance that continued to present challenges for those affected by its jurisdiction. The new update will include a series of stakeholder meetings and will be developed in conjunction with the Army Corps of Engineers.

Proposal to List Monarch Butterfly as Threatened Under the Endangered Species Act

The U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service published a proposal in the Federal Register on December 12, 2024, to list the monarch butterfly as threatened with species-specific protections and flexibilities to encourage conservation under section 4(d) of the Endangered Species Act. The proposal also designates critical habitat along the Central Coast. CAFB submitted comments on March 12, 2025. The public comment period will likely be reopened to accept additional comments.

Comments On Proposed Merced River Draft Clean Water Act Section 401 Hydropower License

CAFB submitted written comments on a draft state water quality certification under Section 401 of the Clean Water Act. This is in connection with two pending hydropower license renewal applications of the Merced Irrigation District, including one license for New Exchequer on the Merced River. CAFB's comments raised objections to the Board's current proposal to make accelerated implementation of the Board's adopted, but still unimplemented 2018 Phase 1 unimpaired flow objectives, 35 to 55 percent January through June, conditions of Merced ID's hydropower license renewal. In this way, it appears the Board improperly seeks to avoid the need for formal water rights proceedings, CEQA compliance, or formal adoption of implementing regulations under the California Administrative Procedures Act. CAFB's comments also urge the Board to consider and approve a voluntary agreement on the Merced River in lieu of the Board's unimpaired flow objectives.

Grower Alert Summary, Beet Leafhopper:

The California Department of Food and Agriculture (CDFA) has issued an alert regarding increased populations of beet leafhopper (BLH) in the San Joaquin Valley (SJV), particularly on isolated southwest-facing slopes near Kettleman City, CA. This surge in BLH numbers is localized, affecting a small portion of the area. Similar fields in Fresno and Kern Counties are being closely monitored for potential outbreaks.

Growers are advised to be aware of the BLH presence detected in surveys from March 21st and to monitor fields adjacent to the affected hillsides. Beet leafhopper samples from growers are being accepted at the CDFA Fresno Office for analysis.

For further details, to report sightings, or inquire about the program, contact Kendra Tapia at the CDFA. Growers can also subscribe to monthly reports and alerts on the Beet Curly Top Virus Control Program.

For more information, visit the CDFA website.

Ag Risk Coverage (ARC)

Agricultural producers who have not yet enrolled in the Agriculture Risk Coverage (ARC) or Price Loss Coverage (PLC) programs for the 2025 crop year have until April 15, 2025, to revise elections and sign contracts. Both safety net programs, delivered by USDA's Farm Service Agency (FSA), provide vital income support to eligible farmers who experience substantial declines in crop prices or revenues for the 2025 crop year. In California, producers have completed 2826 contracts to date, representing 39% of the more than 7423 expected contracts. For more information contact the Kings County FSA Office.

USDA Expediting $10 Billion in Direct Economic Assistance to Agricultural Producers(ECAP)

Program payments to offset increased input costs, market decline.

U.S. Secretary of Agriculture Brooke Rollins, on National Agriculture Day, announced that the U.S. Department of Agriculture (USDA) is issuing up to $10 billion directly to agricultural producers through the Emergency Commodity Assistance Program (ECAP) for the 2024 crop year. Administered by USDA's Farm Service Agency (FSA), ECAP will help agricultural producers mitigate the impacts of increased input costs and falling commodity prices.

Authorized by the American Relief Act, 2025, these economic relief payments are based on planted and prevented planted crop acres for eligible commodities for the 2024 crop year. To streamline and simplify the delivery of ECAP, FSA will begin sending pre-filled applications to producers who submitted acreage reports to FSA for 2024 eligible ECAP commodities soon after the signup period opens on March 19, 2025. Producers do not have to wait for their pre-filled ECAP application to apply. They can visit fsa.usda.gov/ecap to apply using a login.gov account or contact their local FSA office to request an application once the signup period opens.

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Excelsior-Kings River Resource Conservation District (EKRCD) $5 Million Healthy Soils Grant

The Excelsior-Kings River Resource Conservation District (EKRCD) is honored to announce a pivotal initiative that will significantly impact sustainable agriculture in central California. The district has secured a $5 million Healthy Soils Block Grant from the California Department of Food and Agriculture (CDFA), designed to bolster sustainable farming practices and improve soil health across parts of Fresno, Kings, and Tulare counties. This funding represents a substantial investment in the future of the region's agricultural landscape.

The Healthy Soils Program is a comprehensive state initiative aimed at promoting farming practices that not only improve soil health but also help mitigate climate change. By focusing on reducing greenhouse gas emissions, enhancing soil fertility, and promoting biodiversity, the program supports farmers and ranchers in adopting methods that improve both environmental and economic sustainability. This is a crucial step for California, where agriculture plays a key role in the state's economy, and ensuring that farming practices align with the state's environmental goals is critical.

In this first round of funding, EKRCD has already allocated approximately $2.4 million to 20 innovative projects across the region. These projects will implement practices that directly enhance soil health, such as composting, soil amendments, pollinator habitat, and water conservation. The goal is to assist local farmers in

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1. It would document abandoned wells and allow the GSA to correct or challenge inflated figures in the State's records.
2. Some of those abandoned wells may be candidates for becoming monitoring sites. These sites could provide key data on groundwater levels and land subsidence without requiring new drilling.

This effort is a proactive move to bring better data, smarter planning, and local context into the SGMA conversation.

Recharge Credit Policy: Designed to Reward Effort

Another policy nearing final approval is the recharge credit policy, which has been carefully reviewed over several meetings.

The committee supports a system providing landowners a 75 percent credit for verified groundwater recharge, including on actively farmed or fallowed land. Credits will carry over for five years, with a small percentage reduction each year. It is important to note that recharge credits must be used within the same aquifer zone where the water was put back into the ground.

This policy was shaped with one clear principle in mind: those who invest in recharge should keep the benefit. The committee was unified in supporting recharge efforts under private control, not shifting them to the GSA or a water district.

This is one of the most practical tools under SGMA, providing flexibility, incentive, and recognition for landowners who are doing their part to restore the groundwater system.

Water Use Measurement: Grounded in Flexibility

Tracking water use is a core requirement under SGMA, but the approach can vary. At the moment, growers can choose between flow meters and ET-based tracking, such as Land IQ (which uses satellite data to estimate evapotranspiration).

The committee supports keeping both options for now. There is an acknowledgment that dairy and industrial operations have more complex water usage and will require some flexibility. However, for row crops and orchards, many landowners prefer the simplicity of ET tracking, which is already widely used.

There's an understanding that the policy may evolve based on what the data shows. But the committee has been clear: SGMA compliance must work in practice, not just on paper.

Shallow Well Mitigation: Protecting Rural Households

SGMA mandates that every subbasin have a mitigation policy. The reality is that the Mid-Kings GSA has the highest probability of needing well mitigation within the entire subbasin due to shallow wells running dry.

The committee is actively working on a shallow well mitigation policy that could offer financial assistance or reimbursement for repairs and replacements. Several models are being considered, including:

- Reimbursement-based support for landowners who manage their own drilling projects
- Potential creation of a locally controlled mitigation fund, tied to SGMA planning

No final recommendation has been made yet, but the conversations are serious and grounded in the belief that this isn't just a water policy; it's a community need.

Looking Ahead: What Comes Next

In the coming weeks, the committee will continue refining several areas:

- Budget projections for well replacement and mitigation
- Review of groundwater level thresholds and monitoring strategies
- Final recommendations on recharge implementation and aquifer zone tracking

SGMA isn't just about state mandates or regulatory deadlines; it's about how those decisions affect your day-to-day operations. Whether it's understanding how to register a well, participating in recharge efforts, or preparing for potential shallow well impacts, the policies discussed this spring will directly shape how water is managed across the Mid-Kings GSA.

The Stakeholder Advisory Committee is working to ensure that those policies are clear, practical, and grounded in real-world ag experience. But none of this happens in a vacuum.

Your awareness, feedback, and participation matter.

Compliance is coming. What we do now, how we plan, adapt, and stay informed, will determine how well we protect our water and our way of life in the years ahead.

SGMA DEFENSE FUND

Join the Fight!

Kings County Farm Bureau's legal challenge against the State Water Resources Control Board has already saved growers in the Tulare Lake Sub-basin millions of dollars and kept state intervention off your farm. But the fight isn't over yet—and we need your support to finish strong. By contributing, you'll play a crucial role in securing a win for California agriculture, protecting farms, and ensuring the future of farming in California. This is a pivotal moment—your support can make all the difference.
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The WAVE Studies SGMA March 7, 2025

By Don A. Wright, WaterWrights

A study conducted by California State University researchers looks at how aware San Joaquin Valley farmers are of the Sustainable Groundwater Management Act (SGMA) and its administration. The Water And Valley Economy, WAVE study was funded by the CSU Agricultural Research Institute as well as cash and in-kind contributions from private enterprises. The study was led by CSU-WATER, Water Advocacy Towards Education & Research and includes faculty, staff and students from Fresno State, Chico State and volunteer collaborators from ag related businesses cooperatively conducted the study over the past year. You can access an presentation of the survey on YouTube https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hf_XYbMx9UE

The Sustainable Groundwater Management Act was passed in 2014 and created an entirely new layer of government. It divided the San Joaquin Valley into hydrologic subbasins and required all land within those subbasins form Groundwater Sustainability Agencies (GSA) by 2017. Each of the GSAs within the subbasins were required to write a coordinated Groundwater Sustainability Plan (GSP) by 2020. This GSP is meant to bring the subbasins into a condition of groundwater balance by the year 2040.

One of the requirements in SGMA is for the GSAs to perform outreach to the people within its boundaries. For many in the ag irrigation community SGMA is now an acronym as familiar as NASA. It's the first major change in water law in a century. But for many growers and businesses in the Valley SGMA is just another undefined government program or they're not even aware of its existence. Yet the implementation of SGMA could so reduce water availability that farms may be forced to permanently fallow one million acres in the Valley.

Study Area

The study area spanned five counties – Madera, Fresno, Kings, Tulare and Kern, 12 subbasins and more than 60 GSAs. The survey was conducted in English, Spanish and Punjabi and was begun in October of 2023. Almost 300 complete responses were received.

Survey Questions

The WAVE Study was headed by **Dr. Steve Blumenshine**, CSU-WATER and **Dr. Anita Chaudhry**, CSU-Chico with input from **Dr. Dean Fairbanks**, CSU-Chico.

The survey portion of the study focused on five questions and five factors to determine farmer engagement. The questions included:

- Were the respondents aware of SMGA and participate in SGMA-related events?
- Are their interests well represented in the GSA?
- What are their perceptions of SGMA's impacts?
- Was the process of SGMA implementation fair?
- What sources of information do farmers use and trust?

The respondents were categorized by their reliance on groundwater in dry and wet years, if their land was within an irrigation or water district, which subbasin and county, the size of the farm and crop types and their education, age and if they also work outside of agriculture.

Results

WAVE Study results were reviewed during a recent webinar. Dr. Chaudhry presented the survey's main results saying most respondents had heard of SGMA but a third had not attended any SGMA related event.

The majority believed participation is important but for logistical reasons didn't attend and didn't feel represented by their GSA.

The responses were mixed when asked about whether they felt their interests were represented by their GSA. Some believed they received poor representation due to divergent interests in the subbasin, a lack of trust amongst farmers and the GSA boards and not receiving coherent information.

The majority of respondents were pessimistic about the effect of SGMA, with the rest either unsure or in some cases optimistic.

Up to 70-percent agreed the process of engaging all farmers was not fair.

Up to 60-percent of respondents reported they don't have adequate information about SGMA.

These information sources differed amongst farmers, some stating they get their information from their Irrigation Districts, the GSAs themselves or neighbors and the local community. However, they all agreed the Department of Water Resources, the State Water Resources Control Board and their counties are not primary sources of information for farmers.

The study found there was a slightly higher response from owners and managers of larger farms, orchards and vineyards relative to the target population. The county wide distribution of survey responses matched the 2022 Ag Census conducted by the US Department of Agriculture.

Responses were received from all subbasins but eight percent marked "I don't know" when asked which subbasin they were located in. Most respondents were inside an irrigation or water district.

The largest reason given for not participating in SGMA events was they didn't know about the event soon enough. The least reason was they didn't know anyone in the GSA.

The responses about quality of representation ranged from "farmers like me" are not well represented to "don't need to attend because I'm well represented." Only one percent felt the GSA meetings are not relevant.

Farmers also working outside of agriculture and farmers growing on less than 180 acres were less likely to participate in SGMA events. While farmers relying more on groundwater were more likely to participate. About half of the respondents who reported not attending a GSA/SGMA event listed logistical barriers prevented them from participating. Such as not learning about the event in time or the location was too inconvenient.

Seventy percent of respondents believed participation of all farmers in their GSAs is essential to achieving groundwater sustainability while 55 percent believed all the farmers in their subbasin have been involved in the SGMA process.

When asked 32 percent felt poorly represented in their GSA, 25 percent were neutral, 26 percent felt well represented and 17 percent were unsure.

The top reasons for pessimism over SGMA are: stakeholders have too many diverse interests, the SGMA timeline is too short, groundwater users are not knowledgeable about groundwater, lack of trust between stakeholders, the GSAs don't have the financial resources and not enough monitoring and extraction data.

There was more pessimism about SGMA's impacts on irrigation supplies, farmers' financial performance and the market value of farmland in both the short and long run.

Conclusions

GSAs need more two-way communication with the broader community to build trust and representation. All agencies need to think beyond a universal, single factor vulnerability to SGMA and avoid the trap of what gets measured gets managed. Groundwater dependence as it impacts the total irrigation supply isn't as well known as it should be.

Overall, the WAVE Study is a first look at how the SGMA process is perceived by those who live and work with water supply uncertainty in the San Joaquin Valley.

Further Observations

Part of the problem of awareness comes from how SGMA was written. Tasking the GSAs to conduct the outreach greatly limited the scope of outreach while complicating the heavy lift of writing a GSP.

For example, if a subbasin has six GSAs with limited geographical areas to reach, that adds six communication requirements to what is largely an engineering and

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Recent and Upcoming Extension Meetings

By Nicholas Clark, M.S., CCA, Farm Advisor

Field days, grower meetings, and agricultural conferences are public events where farmers, crop consultants, pest control advisers, and anybody interested in learning about what's new in agriculture can come listen to presentations, view demonstrations and converse with researchers. The University of California Cooperative Extension plays the role of coordinating many of these meetings and often collaborates with other organizations to put them on. This article will cover some recent extension events and direct readers to websites where they can find presentations and writings from those events.

In September of 2024, the annual Kearney Forage and Field Crops Day took place at the UC Kearney Agricultural Research and Extension Center in Parlier, CA. At this field day, attendees got a chance to tour the research farm and visit with researchers at their trial sites to learn about results, view plots and the effects of various treatments like new varieties of blackeye beans and watch a sprayer calibration demonstration. Then visitors came indoors mid-morning until lunch to view a few slideshow presentations and discuss the shared information with researchers in open question and answer sessions. Registration was free to attendees thanks to generous sponsors from the ag industry. Each year, the presentations and handouts given at this field day are posted online. You can find the materials shared at the 2024 field day at the following webpage: https://alfalfa.ucdavis.edu/Kearney-Alfalfa-Forage-Field-Day-2024. This year, the field day is scheduled to be held on Thursday, September 18, 2025. Keep on the lookout for an agenda.

In November of 2024, the biannual UC Golden State Dairy Management Conference was held at Harvest Hall of the Stanislaus County Ag Center in Modesto, CA. At this conference, renowned economist Corey Geiger gave the keynote speech about the economic outlook for the dairy industry. Attendees then were able to choose between breakout sessions to listen to and watch slideshow presentations ranging from herd health to manure management to forage crop management. After the breakout sessions, the attendees came back together to hear presentations from Dairy Cares and the CA Dairy Research Foundation to learn about how the dairy industry's research dollars have been put to work in specific projects. These presentations emphasized the positive impacts these projects have had or are anticipated to have for the dairy industry. Much of the same program at this conference was repeated at the 2025 Farm Show in Tulare. The next UC Golden State Dairy Management Conference is scheduled for a date to be determined in 2026. The presentations from the November conference can be found on the following webpage: https://ucanr.edu/sites/CAdairyconference/Conference_Information/2024_Agenda/index.cfm.

Covering Tulare, Kings, and Fresno Counties, you can contact me anytime by email at neclark@ucanr.edu . Don't forget, our general farm, garden, youth, and nutrition support for you is only a phone call away. Somebody is always answering or taking messages at the Tulare County UCCE office: 559-684-3300.

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cameras allow law enforcement to stay one step ahead of criminals by moving surveillance to where it is needed most.

Why More Mobile Flock Cameras Are Needed

Currently, the Ag Crimes Unit has only one mobile Flock Camera, purchased through the Sheriff's Department budget. However, law enforcement officials believe an optimal system would include six to eight mobile cameras to monitor crime trends across the county effectively. Given the budgetary constraints local law enforcement agencies face, acquiring additional cameras requires community support.

To help bridge the gap, the Kings County Farm Bureau's Board of Directors has stepped in to fund the purchase of two additional mobile Flock Camera systems. This contribution is a significant step toward strengthening rural security, but more assistance is needed to expand the mobile surveillance network.

Real-World Impact of Flock Cameras

The effectiveness of Flock Cameras is already evident in Kings County. These cameras have been crucial in solving multiple agricultural crimes, including high-profile equipment thefts. Investigators have successfully tracked stolen tractors and other machinery across county lines, identifying suspects and recovering stolen property.

One recent case, "Operation Tractor Pull," exemplifies the power of this technology. The investigation utilized Flock Camera data to trace stolen agricultural equipment from Kings County through Tulare County and beyond. By tracking vehicle movements, law enforcement intercepted the stolen equipment before it could be sold or dismantled.

Additionally, Flock Cameras have been instrumental in combating widespread copper wire theft, which has plagued local farms. These thefts result in financial losses and disrupt essential irrigation and power systems. By monitoring suspect vehicles in areas where wire thefts occur, authorities have been able to make arrests and prevent further damage.

A Call to Action: How You Can Help

Ensuring the security of our rural communities is a shared responsibility. The Kings County Ag Crimes Unit seeks donations from individuals, businesses, and agricultural organizations to expand the mobile Flock Camera system. Every contribution, no matter the size, will help deter crime and protect local farmers and ranchers.

By supporting this initiative, donors can help:

- Expand the number of mobile Flock Cameras deployed throughout the county
- Enhance law enforcement's ability to identify and apprehend suspects quickly
- Reduce financial losses for farmers and agribusinesses
- Strengthen the overall security infrastructure in Kings County

To contribute, interested individuals and organizations are encouraged to contact the Kings County Sheriff's Department.

The Bigger Picture: The Future of Agricultural Crime Prevention

In addition to investing in Flock Cameras, the Ag Crimes Unit is working on broader legislative efforts to combat agricultural theft. One notable development is Assembly Bill 1218 (AB 1218), which aims to make the possession of stolen copper wire a felony offense in California. This bill, supported by local law enforcement and district attorneys, seeks to close existing legal loopholes that allow criminals to escape prosecution for copper theft.

Another crucial advancement is the increasing use of GPS tracking technology on farm equipment. These affordable and discreet devices allow farmers to track stolen machinery in real time, leading to faster recoveries and reducing overall theft rates. As technology evolves, law enforcement and the agricultural community must work together to implement innovative solutions that keep farms and rural properties safe.

Conclusion

Agricultural crime affects everyone in Kings County, from small family farms to large-scale agribusinesses. By investing in security measures such as Flock Cameras, we can take a proactive stance against theft and vandalism. The Kings County Ag Crimes Unit, with the support of the Farm Bureau and residents, is committed to making our rural communities safer.

We urge the community to support this initiative. Every effort counts, whether through financial contributions, spreading awareness, or advocating for stronger legislation. By working together, we can protect our farms, safeguard our resources, and ensure a more secure future for Kings County's agricultural industry.

For more information on how to donate or get involved, please get in touch with the Kings County Farm Bureau today. Your support can make a real difference in the fight against agricultural crime.

Ag Commissioner's Compliance Report

Jimmy Hook, Agricultural Commissioner/Sealer

Protecting California's Crops: The Curly Top Virus Control Program

California's vast agricultural landscape is constantly under threat from pests and diseases, one of the most persistent being the Beet Curly Top Virus (BCTV). This devastating plant virus, spread by the beet leafhopper, poses a serious risk to crops such as tomatoes, peppers, melons, sugar beets, and other valuable produce. To manage the economic impact of BCTV throughout the state the California Department of Food and Agriculture (CDFA) established the Beet Curly Top Virus Control Program (BCTVCP) in 1943, in accordance with California Agricultural Code , section 6031-6043.

The BCTVCP is funded through the assessment of impacted crops, with the rate of assessment being based on region and level of impact. Program activities are based on the recommendation of the Beet Curly Top Virus Control Board. The BCTVC Board consists of 9 members representing the 4 districts serviced by the program.

How the Program Works

The BCTVCP focuses on monitoring, controlling, and reducing the beet leafhopper (BLH) populations, the sole vector of BCTV. These tiny yet destructive insects transmit the virus by feeding on infected plants and then spreading it to healthy crops. Unlike many plant diseases, CTV has no cure, making prevention and vector control the most effective strategies.

In California, BLH overwinter in the foothills of the Coastal Range, west of the Central Valley. There, BLH feed and lay eggs on perennial weeds (e.g. filaree [Erodium spp.], peppergrass, various mustard species, and buckhorn plantain [Plantago lanceolata]) that germinate following seasonal rain. These host weeds can be infected with BCTV, which BLH ingest and accumulate as they feed.

As the rain stops and the foothills dry, viruliferous BLH migrate to the Central Valley floor in search of annual weeds (e.g. Russian thistle [Salsola tragus L.], Chenopodium species including lambsquarter and goosefoot, and London rocket [Sisymbrium irio]) to complete their life cycle. As BLH migrate to the valley floor in search of preferred annual weeds, they feed on susceptible agricultural crop plants, infecting them with BCTV and potentially causing damage.

The BLH's migration to the valley floor tends to occur between March and April. This coincides with the start of the growing season, when BCTV-susceptible crops are at their most vulnerable stages of early growth. However, while most incidence of BCTV infection occur at the start of the season, infection can occur throughout the growing season. This is because BLH can persist on the valley floor for three generations, with the potential to continue spreading the virus as they move from host weed to crop. In late fall, BLH return to the foothills to overwinter.

Each year, program specialists conduct Spring and Fall surveys to track leafhopper populations and determine high-risk areas. Year-round BCTVCP surveys focus on the San Joaquin Valley, because historically that is where the highest incidence of BCTV occurs. Additional surveys are conducted throughout the year, as resources allow. Commodity surveys begin in June, BCTVCP personnel transition their surveys to agricultural crops that are susceptible to BCTV. BCTV damage assessment surveys are conducted and percent damage due to BCTV is recorded. Personnel collect samples of BCTV symptomatic plant tissue and submit them to the CDFA Plant Diagnostic Lab for viral analysis.

They then implement targeted control measures, including environmentally responsible insecticide applications in rangelands and uncultivated areas where leafhoppers breed. By focusing efforts on these areas before the insects migrate to farmlands, the program helps minimize outbreaks and crop losses.

Why It Matters

Since the early 1900s, curly top disease has been a known cause of serious crop damage across the Western United States. Curly top disease is caused by BCTV, which belongs to the family Geminiviridae, and genus Curtovirus. BCTV infects approximately 300 species of crop and weed plant species, and importantly, causes significant damage to sugar beets, tomatoes, spinach, melons, hemp, peppers, and other economically critical crops in Arizona, California, Colorado, Idaho, New Mexico, and Utah.

Looking Ahead

Since its initiation, the BCTVCP has successfully reduced the severity of BCTV outbreaks in California through constant monitoring and control of beet leafhopper (BLH) populations, the sole vector of BCTV. This management strategy utilizes both aerial and ground control methods. Control operations primarily take place in the San Joaquin Valley; however, the BCTVCP monitors both BLH populations and BCTV outbreaks throughout California.

For more information about the Curly Top Virus Control Program and how it supports California agriculture, visit the California Department of Food and Agriculture's website.

Feel free to contact Kings County Department of Agriculture at (559) 852-2830 with questions or for additional information.

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Kings County Rural Crime Report

This month, the Rural Crimes Unit investigated the following Ag-related crimes, which led to several arrests.

We took a wire theft from an irrigation pump near the 7500 block of Whitley Ave in Corcoran, where approximately $2800 of wire was stolen. A vehicle tire impression and a dirt bike tire impression were located at this scene. It is unknown if the dirt bike was involved in this theft, but we ask you to keep an eye out for any dirt bikes riding on your property in the Corcoran area.

In the area of 10 1/2 Ave and Nevada Ave in Corcoran 200 feet of copper wire was stolen from an Ag pump at Chaparral Farm #3. Tire impressions found were similar to the above mentioned theft.

Near Highway 41 and Quebec Avenue in Kettleman City there was a report taken of approximately 300 feet of 24F Prysmian Optical wire stolen which was valued at $2100.

In the area of Highway 41 and Laurel Avenue there was a total of 260 feet of 50 pair and 100 pair of AT&T wire, which was stolen and valued at $2000.

The Rural Crimes Unit conducted a traffic stop on a vehicle which has been involved with prior property theft crimes. A search of the vehicle was conducted and approximately 125 pounds of striped wire was located. The wire was confiscated for safekeeping and two male subjects were arrested for drug related charges.

The Rural Crimes Unit conducted surveillance in Kettleman City in an attempt to locate and arrest Hugo Estrada Mora regarding multiple AT&T wire thefts. Hugo was identified as bringing wire into a local recycle yard approximately 24 times which has cost AT&T thousands of dollars in damage. Kings County Deputies have taken approximately (26) AT&T wire theft reports ranging from January of 2024 until present. A traffic stop was conducted on Hugo in Kettleman City. During a vehicle search, tools used to cut wire and AT&T wire remnants were located inside his vehicle. Hugo was arrested on multiple AT&T wire theft violations as well as felony vandalism, arson, and copper wire theft. His bail was set at $840,000.

The Rural Crimes Unit and the Fresno County Sheriff's Office conducted a probation search in Selma regarding wire thefts in Kings County. The suspect, Elizabeth Nixon, was wanted for recycling stolen AT&T wire out of Kings County. During the search of her property AT&T wire was located and Elizabeth was arrested. She was transported to the Kings County Jail for copper wire-related charges.

Rural Crimes Unit assisted California Department of Fish and Wildlife with multiple search warrants near 6th Avenue and the Kern County line with an illegal marijuana grow. A total of 2,240 marijuana plants were eradicated. During the eradication of the second grow, two pieces of stolen equipment were located which were described as a Trime light tower and a 1,000-gallon polymer water tank. Both items were later determined to be stolen. The light tower belonged to Dragados Flatiron out of Selma which was valued at nearly $18,000 and the water tank belonged to Simplot out of Terra Bella which was valued at approximately $1000. They were both turned over to their respective owners.

The theft of a tractor and disc were reported by Westhaven Agribusiness as being stolen in the area of the Avenal Cutoff and 30th Avenue. The tractor was described as a, John Deere, 5100GN model, valued at $60,000 and a 6 1/2 foot Domries disc, valued at $4,000. A search for the tractor was conducted in the Avenal area, on the same day, and ultimately a tractor matching the description of the stolen John Deere tractor was located, just north of Avenal, off of Highway 33. The suspect, Enrique Teran, was questioned on scene and admitted to taking the tractor. He also had multiple active warrants out of Kings County and was later booked into the Kings County Jail for his warrants and fresh charges to include possession of stolen property, taking of a vehicle without permission, and an enhancement was added to his charge. This enhancement was added, due to the fact Prop 36 was passed last November by the California voters. **The enhancement is defined as "when a person takes, damages, or destroys property or commits a 496 (possession of stolen property), the court may add an enhancement if the loss or damage exceeds $50,0000, and can add 1 year state prison.** This is the first time in Kings County this enhancement was added to a theft charge and, if convicted, this will add an additional 1 year of state prison to his sentencing.

The Rural Crimes Unit set up a booth for Farm Day at the Kings County Fairgrounds where approximately 2000, 3rd grade students learned about the agriculture industry. It was a pleasure to interreact with the kids and we are looking forward to attending next year.

If any member would like to obtain an Owner Applied Number (OAN) please contact our Ag Unit and one will be issued to you. We can also stamp the OAN on your property at no charge if requested.

We continue to investigate Ag related thefts and encourage members to call and report all Ag related crimes. If we do not receive calls from our members and community, we may not be aware of certain crimes occurring in your area. If you have any questions, feel free to call me or any of our unit members at any time. **Detective Santos (559) 904-6893, Detective Estrada (559) 212-7512 or Investigator Ward (559) 280-5441.**

"WaterWrights" continued from page 7

planning task. The state isn't paying for the cost of writing the GSP, it is self-funded by farmers. The GSA board members must be good stewards of these funds and it would be irresponsible for them to pay for outreach beyond the GSA boundaries.

The GSPs are mostly written by hydrologic engineers and attorneys and they cost millions of dollars to produce. The outreach component ends up being written by technical specialists. While they are extremely skilled in hydrology, computer modeling and legal procedure – public relations and marketing are not something they usually deal with.

In many instances Non-Government Organizations, NGOs, received grant money to conduct outreach to disadvantaged communities, DACs. Although not included in the WAVE Study there is empirical evidence few DAC residents attended SGMA events. By that metric the NGO efforts have proven a nonviable method of outreach.

In retrospect, had SGMA made the outreach component subbasin wide, all of the GSAs could contribute to a larger outreach effort increasing the economy of scale and effectiveness.

Since implementing SGMA has never been done before there are no precedents or experiences to draw from. It will be very important for everyone – farmers, GSAs, state agencies – to remember there may be many more 20/20 hindsight visions of how SGMA could have been better written and be willing to be flexible and work together. That goes especially for the state since they have the regulatory power.

Note: In addition to Risk Mitigators & Advisors and Umida Agriculture WaterWrights.net has donated in-kind contributions to this study.

For more information contact: Dr. Steve Blumenshine at sblumens@mail.fresnostate.edu

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"EKRCD" continued from page 5

improving the resilience and long-term productivity of their farms.

Looking Ahead: The Second Round of Funding

While the first round of funding marks a significant milestone, the work is far from over. EKRCD is excited to announce the opening of a second round of funding, which will be available from May 1 through June 30, 2025. With $1.6 million allocated for on-farm projects, this is an incredible opportunity for farmers in the region to secure financial support for their sustainability projects. The second round of funding promises to expand the scope of the program and allow even more farmers to join in the effort to improve soil health and sustainability.

In addition to the financial support, the application process for the second round of funding is designed to ensure that applicants are well-prepared and that their projects align with the goals of the Healthy Soils Program. A critical component of this process is the involvement of Technical Assistance Providers (TAPs), who offer expertise in project design, budgeting, and compliance. TAPs serve as guides, helping applicants navigate the often complex process of applying for funding and ensuring that the proposed projects are both innovative and feasible.

Supporting Farmers with Expertise and Resources

One of the key figures in supporting applicants is Dusty Ference, the designated TAP for EKRCD. With years of experience in sustainable farming practices, Dusty offers one-on-one support to farmers, answering questions, providing guidance on project development, and helping with the completion of grant applications. Dusty's knowledge of both the technical and practical aspects of farming will be invaluable to anyone seeking to implement soil health practices on their farm.

Dusty's role is to make sure that farmers understand the full potential of the Healthy Soils Block Grant program and how to maximize its benefits. By working closely with growers, Dusty ensures that their projects are impactful and aligned with environmental and sustainability goals. This personalized assistance is crucial for farmers who may be new to sustainable practices or who may have concerns about navigating the application process.

A Call to Action for Central California Farmers

If you are a farmer or rancher in Fresno, Kings, or Tulare counties, now is the time to get involved in this transformative initiative. The upcoming application period, from May 1 to June 30, 2025, is your chance to receive the funding and support necessary to implement sustainable farming practices that benefit both your operation and the environment. Whether you are interested in improving soil health, adopting composting practices, or exploring other conservation efforts, this grant program provides a powerful opportunity to make a lasting difference.

For those ready to apply or who have questions about the application process, Dusty Ference is here to help. Contact Dusty for personalized assistance and to ensure your project proposal is as strong as possible. Together, we can make significant strides toward a healthier, more sustainable agricultural future for the Central Valley of California. For more information and to contact EKRCD, visit www.ekrcd.org.

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Steven E. Alfieris • Ella R. Floresca
David M. Lange • Dustin J. Moses
Alyssa T. Ransom
Attorneys at Law

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